A FREE ENCOUNTER · LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

The Scaffold

An encounter for four characters of 4th level, scaling to 3rd and 5th. 5e-compatible (SRD 5.1).

One location · 45 to 60 minutes · one fight · one d8 · fifth edition (SRD 5.1)

The hook

The man who built the scaffold on the new temple has not been paid for it, so he has gone up it with four men and five axes to take it down at noon, with the bell slung underneath and the square full of people who paid to watch the bell go in.

At a glance: one location · 45 to 60 minutes · one fight, forty feet up · no loot.

♦

The setup

Saint Sidwell's has been going up on the north side of the square for three years. Its tower is not finished, and up the street face of the tower stands a scaffold of four lifts: fir poles lashed with hemp, a planked deck every ten feet, a ladder from each deck to the next, and at every lift a pole run through a hole in the wall and lashed to the frame, which is what holds the frame to the tower. The top deck is forty feet up. Under it, in a rope cradle hung from a gin wheel, is the bell, waiting to be swung in through the tower's west opening at noon.

The warden of Saint Sidwell's, Ninian Ribble, sold the square. A silver piece bought a place to stand, the beadles put hurdles across the side streets so that nobody stands without paying, and the square is full from the temple step to the inn rail, four hundred people.

Hamon Comber raised the scaffold in the spring with a crew of four, on the warden's word and a paper that says the frame stands at the scaffolder's own charge until the bell is hung. Comber read that as paid when the bell is hung; Ribble reads it as paid out of the plate, once the bell is ringing people in. Three months, four askings, nothing. His price is thirty gold.

An hour before noon Comber and his men went up the yard-side ladder with hand axes under their coats, pulled the lowest ladder up after them, and climbed to the top deck.

The party is at the foot of the scaffold because Ribble hired them this morning, two silver each, to keep the crowd off the frame and the boys off the ladders.

READ ALOUD

The square is full and warm and smells of pies. Up the raw face of the tower the scaffold goes in four steps of grey pole and yellow plank, and under the top deck the bell hangs in its cradle of rope, new bronze. There are men on the top deck. Five of them, standing easy, not working. The one at the wall end has a hand axe resting on the lashing where the frame meets the tower, the way a man rests his hand on a gate. The lowest ladder is lying along the second deck, pulled up. A boy near you says, loud, "That's Comber."

♦

What's really going on

Comber is not bluffing and he is not in a hurry. He wants thirty gold counted into his hand in front of the people Ribble sold the square to. His sentence to the stand: *"Thirty gold by the noon bell, or I take my poles back the quick way."*

The quick way: two ties hold the top lift to the tower, one at each end of the deck, and an axe parts a tie in one stroke. With both gone the frame stands on its own feet, and the next thing that strikes it, which Comber intends to be the bell shoved off the deck lip, takes forty feet of fir and plank and half a ton of bronze out into the street. He knows who is under it. He has looked.

Play him as a man who has finished arguing. He answers anyone who says the word *paid* and nobody else, and he cuts the first tie when one of three things happens: Ribble refuses him out loud, anybody who is not his sets foot on the second lift, or the handbell rings for noon. His men cut on his word; the second tie he cuts himself. A character who reads him (**Wisdom (Insight), DC 13**) sees that he means it and is waiting for a number; on a failure he reads as a man working himself up to a thing, which he finished doing a week ago.

READ ALOUD

> *"They paid him to stand there," Comber says down to the stand, not loud, and the square carries it. "Nobody paid me. The poles are mine. A man can take down his own scaffold."*

Ninian Ribble is on the stand with the handbell, the clerk and a cashbox, and the box holds more than thirty gold. He will not pay. The money is there; what is not there is a warden who will be watched paying a man with an axe, because the town would learn by nightfall what a paper is worth against one. He would rather lose the bell. Nobody fights Ribble. The two beadles (SRD *guards*) hold the hurdles, and that is all they do.

♦

The interesting choice

Comber has given the square until noon, which is ten minutes, and the party has three courses.

- **Go up.** Climb to the top deck and stop five men with axes from cutting two lashings. Everything above the first lift is a fight on a deck the width of a door, over a crowd, against men who stand two to an end so that whoever comes up the ladder arrives between them. Anything that goes off the street side lands on somebody.
- **Clear the street.** Give the scaffold up and get the people out from under it. The square was built this morning to keep people in: the hurdles are lashed, the beadles hold them, and the one way out that opens quickly is the inn yard, which takes ten minutes, which is the ten Comber gave.
- **Pay him.** Thirty gold ends it. The box on the stand has it and Ribble will not open the box. The party may talk him into it, take it from him, or pay out of their own purses; Comber takes money from anyone, and he comes down for it.

♦

Mechanics

The scaffold. The decks are ten, twenty, thirty and forty feet up, each four planks wide, which is three feet. A ladder is movement and no roll. Climbing a standard without a ladder is a **DC 13 Strength (Athletics)** check for each lift, at half speed; on a failure the character goes nowhere this turn and does not fall. Anyone on the deck above attacks a climber with advantage.

On a deck. A creature pushed off a deck goes off the street side. A creature knocked prone on a deck makes a **DC 13 Dexterity saving throw** or slides off. Comber's men have half cover from the planks and the bell against anything shot from the square, and a creature reduced to 0 hit points on a deck stays on the deck.

Falling. 1d6 bludgeoning damage for every ten feet. A fall onto the deck below is ten feet; roll on the table. A fall into the street lands on a person, who takes the same damage and has four hit points. From the second lift up, whatever goes off the street side kills somebody.

The crowd. A clear order from above, from someone they can see, is a **DC 13 Charisma (Intimidation or Persuasion)** check: on a success the people directly under the frame go ten feet back in one round, and nothing moves

them further until the inn yard is open; on a failure they look up, and people who are looking up stand still. The inn yard takes the beadles ten minutes to open, and the party cannot make it faster.

Talking to Comber (Charisma (Persuasion), DC 15). He listens to any sentence with *paid* in it, and each success buys the speaker a round of his attention; after three he lets one character come up the ladder, alone and unarmed, to put money in his hand. Nothing else moves him.

Talking to Ribble (Charisma (Persuasion) or (Intimidation), DC 15). Persuasion has advantage if the character points at the people under the frame rather than at Comber. On a success he opens the box and counts thirty gold into whoever's hand. On a failure he says he will pay when the bell is rung, which is the thing Comber will not wait for.

The cutting. A wall tie is cut by a creature standing on that deck with an axe or a sword: one action, no roll. With both top ties cut, the next thing that strikes the frame brings it down: the bell shoved off the deck lip (one action, by anyone on the top deck), a body falling onto a deck, a *thunderwave*, anything. Do not roll on the table once the top ties are gone; it goes.

When the frame goes. Everyone on it falls the height of their deck and lands in the street. The frame covers the width of the street along the whole face of the tower; everyone under it takes 4d6 bludgeoning damage, and a commoner has four hit points. The bell kills whoever it lands on.

Comber's crew (4). The SRD *thug* stat block: AC 11, 32 hit points, two attacks at +4 for 1d6 + 2, and Pack Tactics. Their maces are hand axes, which changes the damage to slashing and nothing else.

Hamon Comber. The SRD *bandit captain* stat block: AC 15, 65 hit points, three attacks a round at +5 (two for 1d6 + 3 and one for 1d4 + 3), and Parry. His scimitar is a hand axe. He stands at the wall-end tie with the axe on the lashing and does not fight until somebody is on the top deck, and then he fights whoever is between him and the second tie.

Encounter math: Comber (CR 2, 450 XP) with four thugs (CR 1/2, 100 XP each) is 850 XP raw, adjusted to **1,700** by the tool (`encounter_xp.py --party 4x4 --cr 2,1/2,1/2,1/2,1/2`), a **Hard** fight for four 4th-level characters against thresholds of 500 / 1,000 / 1,500 / 2,000. All five are on the top deck from the first round and nothing arrives later. The deck is the party's lever: at most two of the five can reach whoever comes up the ladder.

♦

What the party reaches for

The standard kit against a scaffold over a crowd, and the ruling on each.

Rope. Fifty feet of hempen rope round a standard and through a putlog hole is a wall tie: one character, one action. A tie the party has tied is one Comber's men must cut, standing on that deck.

A grappling hook. Over the top ledger in one throw. The rope is a standard to climb, DC 13 Strength (Athletics) per lift, and it arrives at the bell, where the axes are.

A ladder from the yard. The yard behind the temple has the ladders Comber's men did not pull up. Two characters carry one through the crowd in two rounds, and the first lift is a ladder again. No roll.

Pitons. Nothing for them to go into. The holes are already in the wall and are the handholds.

Light. It is noon.

A mount. A horse in a packed square moves nobody and climbs nothing. Standing on its back reaches the first deck without a roll.

Feather fall. Up to five falling creatures land unhurt. It saves whoever is falling and nobody the frame lands on; the frame is not a creature.

Levitate. One creature, twenty feet a round. Two rounds put a fighter on the top deck. Cast on one of Comber's men instead, Constitution save, and a man hanging in the air with an axe cuts nothing for ten minutes.

Fly. Sixty feet of flying speed puts one character on the top deck in one turn, alone, with five men and an axe on the tie. Let it.

Misty step. Thirty feet, to a place the caster can see. The third deck is seen from the square; the caster is on it in a bonus action and on the top deck the next turn.

Spider climb. Up the wall beside the frame at full speed, no roll, and onto any deck from the wall side, where nobody stands.

Mage hand. Ten pounds. A lashing under the weight of the frame does not untie and an axe does not leave a hand. It will ring the handbell on the stand, which is the noon signal.

Shatter. Ten feet of thunder that damages objects. On the top lift it is the cut Comber came to make, done for him, and everyone on it saves and then falls. Lower, roll on the table.

Thunderwave. A fifteen-foot cube and a ten-foot push. Every man on the deck who fails goes off the street side onto the people below, and the planks roll on the table.

♦

Outcomes

- **They stop the cutting** → Comber is taken on the top deck, or thrown off it, and the bell goes in at noon. Ribble pays the party their two silver each and does not pay Comber, and the paper stands.
- **They clear the street** → the frame and the bell come down on empty cobbles, and the bell cracks. Comber climbs down the yard side with his axe on his shoulder, and the party can take him at the yard gate if they want him, because the beadles will not. Ribble has no bell, no scaffold, and four hundred people who want their silver back.
- **They pay him** → Comber counts it on the top deck, in front of everyone, and comes down the yard ladder and goes. The bell goes in at noon on a frame with a cut tie in it, which holds.
- **The frame comes down on the people** → the number is in the mechanics, and the bell is in the middle of it. Comber is in the street with his men, under his own poles, where he said he would be.

What they leave with: two silver each, if Ribble is still a man who pays. No loot.

♦

Scaling

- **3rd level:** Comber with three thugs, 750 XP raw, **1,500 adjusted**, a **Hard** fight against thresholds of 300 / 600 / 900 / 1,600.
- **Below 3rd:** do not. A fall from the second lift is 2d6 and the crowd makes every fall a death.
- **4th level:** Comber with four thugs as written, **1,700 adjusted**, **Hard**.
- **5th level:** Comber with six thugs, 1,050 XP raw, **2,625 adjusted**, a **Medium** fight against thresholds of 1,000 / 2,000 / 3,000 / 4,400. The two extra stand on the third lift and come up behind whoever climbs.
- **Larger party:** add thugs on the third lift. There is one Comber.

What the scaffold does when something hits it

Roll whenever something heavy strikes the frame while the top ties still hold: a creature falling onto a deck, a creature shoved into a standard, a *thunderwave*, a *shatter*, the bell swung. Once the top ties are cut, do not roll; it goes.

D8	WHAT IT DOES
1	**A plank goes.** The plank under whatever hit tips off its ledger and into the street. Each creature standing on it makes a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw or drops to the deck below, ten feet, and you roll here again.
2	**A lashing lets go.** One end of the deck drops a foot. Every creature on that deck makes a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw or is prone, and a prone creature on a deck makes the save again or slides off.
3	**The bay leans.** The whole frame moves a hand's width out from the wall and stops. Every creature on the scaffold, every lift, makes a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw or is prone. The square sees it move and makes a sound.
4	**The sling swings.** The bell swings out and back across the top deck. Every creature on the top deck makes a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw or takes 2d6 bludgeoning damage and is shoved five feet along the deck. It hangs still after that, a foot further out, and is three-quarters cover against the square.
5	**A ladder goes.** The ladder from the deck that was struck to the deck above comes off its lashing and goes into the street. That lift is the standard now: DC 13 Strength (Athletics) to climb it.
6	**The tools go.** A basket of nails and a hod go off the lip of the deck and into the people. Nobody is hurt much, and everybody under the frame stops and looks up, and will not move for anybody for one round.
7	**It holds.** The frame takes it, creaks, and stands. Comber's men look at Comber.
8	**A tie opens.** The street-side top tie groans and the hemp opens a finger's width. One more blow on that tie, from anything, parts it, and it counts as cut.

Running this somewhere else

The fight wants a narrow deck, a height that kills, and a crowd that cannot move. If your game has no bandit captain, any armed man with sixty-odd hit points and a reason will do. The argument needs no rules at all: a paper that says one thing, a man who read it another way, and a warden who would rather lose a bell than be seen to pay.

The adventures are mine. 30+ years of real tables.

LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

Compatible with fifth edition. Portions derived from the System Reference Document 5.1, © Wizards of the Coast LLC, licensed under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC-BY-4.0). The Scaffold, Hamon Comber, Ninian Ribble and Saint Sidwell's are original content © Long Island Dungeon Master, free to use at your table and in your own work under CC BY 4.0.